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1 The Position

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1.1 Installment 1: “Folkebladet” March 13, 1918

For several years certain disagreements have made themselves felt in Folkebladet concerning the Free Church’s Guiding Principles, regarding what they mean and what consequences they entail. There has been much discussion about it.¹

The discussion does not seem willing to cease. It is almost as if the Free Church has a broken arm that must be set. The sufferer’s thoughts remain on the broken arm until it is healed. Since the understandings of the principles are exceedingly different, frictions arise. They may often look worse than they are, and those who are involved in the frictions may meanwhile

¹Guiding Principles:

1. The congregation is, according to God’s Word, the proper form of the Kingdom of God on earth.
2. The congregation consists of believing people who, by the use of the means of grace and the gifts of grace according to the direction of God’s Word, seek their own salvation and eternal blessedness and that of all their fellow men.
3. According to the New Testament, the congregation requires an outward organization with a register of its members, election of office-bearers, fixed times and places for its gatherings, etc.
4. Since not all members of the congregation’s outward organization are always believing people, and since such sinners often take false comfort from their outward connection with the congregation, it is the congregation’s holy calling to purify itself both by awakening proclamation of God’s Word, by earnest admonition and reminder, and by exclusion of manifest and obstinate sinners.
5. The congregation governs its own affairs under the authority of God’s Word and Spirit, and acknowledges no other ecclesiastical authority or power over itself.
6. The free congregation esteems and loves all the spiritual gifts which the Lord grants for its edification, and seeks to enliven the gifts and promote their use.
7. The free congregation receives with gladness the mutual help which the congregations can render one another in the work of advancing the Kingdom of God.
8. Such mutual help consists partly in this, that the spiritual powers of one congregation come the other to good through free meetings, mutual visits, lay activity, etc.; partly in this, that the congregations voluntarily and according to the prompting of God’s Spirit work together for the solution of such tasks as may exceed the powers of a single congregation.
9. Among such purposes are named in particular a seminary for pastors, the dissemination of Bibles and other writings and papers, Home Mission, mission to the heathen, mission to the Jews, deaconess homes, orphanages, and other works of mercy.
10. Free congregations have no right to require that other congregations submit to their opinion, will, judgment, or determination, wherefore every dominion of a majority of congregations over a minority is to be rejected.
11. The common organs which may be found desirable for the cooperation of the congregations, such as larger or smaller meetings, committees, office-bearers, etc., cannot in a Lutheran Free Church impose upon the single congregation any duty, bond, compulsion, or burden, but are only authorized to come forward with proposals and exhortations to congregations and persons.
12. Every free congregation has, like each individual believer, under the impulse of God’s Spirit and by the right of love, the right to do good and to labor for the salvation of souls and the awakening of spiritual life, as far as its ability and strength reach; in such free, spiritual activity it is restricted neither by parish ties nor by denominational boundaries.

be exposed to harsh judgments. These judgments can sound quite peculiar, for example like the one a little schoolboy wrote in a composition about a horse: “The horse is a very fierce animal. If you attack him he will kick you.” So it can happen that men such as Birkeland and myself may be thought both brute beasts and ‘fierce’.

But, as has been said, so long as the arm is in pain, the thoughts remain fixed on it. And so it is with the principles. It is possible that they amount to more than an arm on the Free Church’s body; it is possible that they mean less. At any rate, they play an exceedingly important role in determining the right to vote at the Free Church’s annual meetings. And surely the meaning is that the principles are to be respected between the annual meetings as well. But so long as there prevails lack of clarity with respect to their meaning and their consequences, it is natural that there should be discussion about them.

More recently, the discussion has centered most sharply on the question: Is Folkebladet against Augsburg? In other words, does the present editors of Folkebladet interpret the conception of the congregation maintained in the Guiding Principles, which were in fact essentially drafted by Sverdrup and Oftedal, who were the leading voices both at Augsburg and in Folkebladet?

From the very beginning of its activity in America, Folkebladet’s founder,² Prof. Oftedal, maintained the conception of the Church set forth in the Guiding Principles, while Sverdrup, it seems, did not place himself fully on his side until after 1876. They were always agreed about ecclesiastical freedom. But in the first couple of years at Augsburg Sverdrup taught, as we still so often find among Lutheran theologians, that the congregation began at Christ’s ascension, not first at the outpouring of the Spirit. In this connection he could say that it was the “first congregation” that chose an apostle to take Judas’s office, whereas later he always taught that the choice of this apostle was not a congregational election, since the congregation was first born at the outpouring of the Spirit. Likewise, he taught that a local congregation, a church body, a branch of the church, is a member of Christ’s body, a stone in God’s temple. “Christ is the head of all, and every congregation is a member of His body, a living stone in the new temple of God.” A church body is “an independent member of the body.” “The Church in its entirety is Christ’s body.” (Collected Writings I.)³

After 1876, and right up to his death, Sverdrup taught, like Oftedal, that the local congregation—not merely the believers considered individually—is not a stone in the temple, nor a member of Christ’s body, but is itself the temple, God’s house, Christ’s body. The other

²Oftedal founded Folkebladet in FIXME.

³Professor Georg Sverdrup Biblical and Church-Historical Sketches and Addresses Edited by Andreas Helland 1909)

ecclesiastical organizations he regarded as historical arrangements, not divinely instituted as the local congregation is, though still useful organs for the congregation. Both Sverdrup and Oftedal were, until the 1890s, advocates of church association in the sense that they desired an association of congregations; but they were not church-body men in the sense that the church body or synod was anything more than an outward expedient.

In faculty opinions, treatises, and in part also sermons, the theological professors at Augsburg again and again set forth that the congregation (the local congregation) is the “only outward form of the Church” (the Church—the holy catholic Church; compare question 243 in the Free Church’s edition of Pontoppidan’s Explanation): “the proper divine order within the Christian religion”; “the truly proper form of Christianity’s manifestation in the world”; “the proper form of God’s kingdom on earth”; the only outward form of His kingdom on earth appointed by God; “the foundational truth of the Church is and remains according to God’s Word the congregation alone and no church body”; “according to Scripture the congregation the highest form of association”; “the outward form of the kingdom of God, which is the congregation.” Prof. Oftedal wrote in the 1870s that Elling Eielsen abolished the visible Church in order to set the invisible Church, the communion of saints, in its place. In Eielsen’s understanding he found “no room for the only outward form of the Church that God’s Word mentions, namely the congregation.” In a long joint declaration from the 1870s it was stated that the church body “has no such divine right as the congregation, but, like all outward church bodies, has arisen through historical development”; likewise that “it belongs inseparably to the essence of the Christian Church to exist in the form of congregations.”

That it is local congregations everywhere that are meant here is self-evident. But this will, moreover, also appear from many other citations in this article. The congregation is everywhere presented as the proper form, set by God, for the holy catholic Church, the Church, or the kingdom, in contrast to “the state-church form, the synodical form, the papal-church form, and the free-church form”, and the “free-church” form. For the time being, it will suffice to refer to the treatise “What Is the Congregation” in Collected Writings II, p. 12, where we read this:

Our children’s catechism teaches what the Church is, but not directly of what the congregation is. The New Testament, however, speaks all the more of the congregation or the congregations. Now people sometimes call them local congregations or ‘local congregations’; and that expression is by no means free from a shade of disrespect that people speak of the local congregations. We therefore take the liberty of observing that what is spoken of here is the “local congregation.” And since it is an unadorned fact that the New Testament speaks

with the deepest reverence and utmost holy seriousness precisely of the local congregations, and calls them God's congregations and God's temple and Christ's body and Christ's bride, it is not too much if we also, with all reverence and respect, speak of this divine institution among us and esteem it very highly for Christ's and God's sake.

Let it be noted that the local congregation is designated a 'divine institution.'

Sverdrup regarded it as a defect in the children's catechism instruction that it did not speak directly of what the congregation was. For this reason he altered question 243⁴ in the Explanation, and wrote: "Is the holy catholic Church found here among us?" His answer reads: "Yes, in the congregation, which in Scripture is called Jesus Christ's body and God's house." The next question, concerning the outward congregation, might lead one to think that the word "congregation" in the answer to question 243 means all believers on earth. But that would be a hasty conclusion, which cannot be defended in the light of all that both Sverdrup and Oftedal wrote about "congregation" and "outward congregation."

Thus the congregation is the proper form. Its rule is the law of Christ's body.

Church bodies, state churches, and free churches (associations of congregations) are not ordered by the law of Christ's body (Guidance II, 33, 145).⁵ We may use an analogy: the congregation is the proper form of the kingdom of God, somewhat as monogamy is the highest form of union between man and woman, in contrast to polygamy. This is admittedly a very imperfect comparison; it limps, as all figures do, since one would then have to reckon the other forms of the kingdom immoral. But the point is plain enough.

This understanding of the congregation as the "proper form" and Christ's body is, so far as Lutherans are concerned, distinctive of the Free Church (and we may add the free-church people in Norway, for example Odland, Jens Orre, Solem; but not The Evangelical Lutheran Free Church). Otherwise I know of no other Lutheran church body in the world that maintains this understanding. All other Lutheran church bodies maintain that "Christ's body," when applied to the concept of the Church, has reference to the holy catholic Church, which consists of all believers on earth, but has no reference to any local congregation. In other words, "Christ's body" must be applied to the whole organism, not to any organization.

In this respect, the Free Church stands almost alone among Lutherans. It is true that a couple of editors in the new church body, The Norwegian Lutheran Church, have stated that this church body also teaches that the congregation is the "proper form." But their statements

⁴FIXME to point to question 243

⁵FIXME point to Guidance II, 33, 145

show that they have not penetrated deeply enough into the Free Church understanding of the congregation. And one cannot hold that against them, seeing that so many of our own people do not have one and the same understanding of principle no. 1 in our “Guiding Principles.” Besides, they are contradicted by Pastor Langjærd in “The Lutheranism of Our Four-Hundred-Year Lutheranism.”

But if this principle is peculiar to the Free Church as a Lutheran body, then they share that principle with Congregationalists and Baptists. It may indeed offend many to hear that we are in such company. But a fact is not abolished by offense. Nor does it make Sverdrup and Oftedal dependent upon the Reformed. Just as open fellowship with Congregationalists or with Baptists no more made the Synod people into Catholics (simply because it accused the Synod of Catholicism), so it does not make Sverdrup and Oftedal dependent upon the Reformed, although Sverdrup already in 1876 thought that we could learn from “such a congregational church as the Reformed has long been,” and that “it would be sheer self-conceit to think that there was nothing to learn from those who have tried these things before us” (the Reformed in America). *Collected Writings I*, 143.

One cannot expect the ordinary man, nor even the pastor strongly occupied in practical work, to be able to find time and occasion to acquaint himself very much with the Lutheran and Reformed literature on church polity. But it is fair to expect of one who writes publicly about the Guiding Principles and criticizes others’ understanding of them, that he acquaint himself with them well enough to know what the principles mean, what is consistent with them, and how much they have in common with Luther and how much or how little they have in common with Calvin. One does not gain much light on the ‘Guiding Principles’ by reading dogmatics, for dogmatics treats the congregation as an object of faith. But one finds light in the literature on church polity and in church history.

But do we not already have all the teaching we need? Have we not sat at the feet of the “older teachers”?

Yes—but how much did we hear there about the “Guiding Principles” and the Augsburg understanding of the congregation? From Oftedal, almost nothing; from Sverdrup, a few lectures when every third year he came to the end of Lønning’s dogmatics, which he mercilessly tore to pieces.

But what we did not hear, that we did get to read in the newspapers. Several of us have read Sverdrup’s and Oftedal’s articles again and again, and in sequence. Here at Augsburg almost everything that Sverdrup and Oftedal wrote is accessible; and almost all the books they used as professors (including the marginal notes they made) are accessible. As far as

possible I have tried to acquaint myself with their work as teachers and public writers, so that I dare say that I have a fairly well-grounded knowledge of their ecclesiastical views.

I hope that no one will take this as though it were spoken in a proud spirit. I am well aware of my limitations. As for me, I did not gallop through Augsburg, as many others did. And when I was finished with Augsburg I had to continue my schooling for three to four years before I could, with a reasonably good academic conscience—if one may use that expression, present myself as a candidate for a pastoral call or a teaching post. And finally, after several years of teaching at other schools, I came to know Augsburg both from near at hand and from a distance, and then came back to it again to know more intimately than ever before. (To be continued.)

1.2 Installment 2: “Folkebladet” April 3, 1918

It will thus be seen that principle no. 1, "the proper chief principle of Scripture" (Veiledning, 143), is by no means a small matter. It is anything but a devout manner of speaking. Its rejection would, to a greater or lesser extent, modify the other fundamental propositions concerning church polity.

The leading principles have again and again been attacked as being at variance with the New Testament's teaching concerning congregation. And in these attacks there has been no lack of proofs from Scripture. I mean that the thoughts which the leading principles interpret, and the consequences which they involve, have fairly often and quite thoroughly been treated in the literature on church polity. The arguments have been both for and against—indirectly against, where Scripture has been broken in order to prove the scripturalness of another concept of the church. For Norway's part it is enough to point to a great number of articles in *Luthersk Kirketidende*, in *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*, and in *Luthersk Ugeskrift*. Germany has a large body of material to offer in its many works on ecclesiastical law and in innumerable contributions interpreting the most various church-political views. And the English Reformed literature on church polity is very extensive.

If we take up principle no. 1, we may first mention Professor von Oettingen (d. 1905) in Dorpat. He was known as a capable Lutheran dogmatician. But he unconditionally rejected the opinion that the New Testament knows only local congregations and contains no "doctrine of the church."

The teacher of ecclesiastical law, Professor Sohm, too, has several times, with good use of passages from Scripture, polemicized against that which principle no. 1 seeks to establish. As the greatest authority on Luther among the jurists, he assures us that Luther could never have agreed with such a principle.

The church historian Professor W. M. Walter in Rostock, unquestionably the greatest living authority on Luther among theologians, says the same of Luther and assures us that Jesus himself could not teach anything such as principle no. 1 teaches: it is too exclusive. (Ev. Luth. Kirchenzeitung, 1913.)

It is in the Reformed literature on church polity that principle no. 1 receives its strongest support. In the Lutheran it receives but little assent. I do not know of a single Lutheran theological faculty of rank in the whole world that would vote for it.

Nor do I know many Lutheran theologians (Professor Odland and Jens Greve must be counted among the exceptions) who agree that this principle is New Testament. The great majority

regard it as Reformed and will doubtless agree with the teacher of ecclesiastical law, Stahl, when he says: "The Reformed church has a strong tendency to let the concept of church pass over into the concept of congregation; it comes to that completely—in its offshoots, the Independents and Baptists, and so forth."

If one wishes to see how the principles of church polity in the Reformed church are judged by Lutherans, one does well to read Sohm's *Kirchenrecht*, pp. 634–657, and especially the jurist Karl Rieker's *Grundsätze reformierter Kirchenverfassung* (about 200 pages), a work that will cast a surprising light upon the leading principles and their consistent interpretation.

But we need not stop with the German Lutherans. We may point to Norway. In 1915–16 a lively discussion concerning the concept of the church was carried on in *Luthersk Kirketidende*. It was between headmaster Jens Greve and parish pastor H. U. Sverdrup. Greve maintained the Free Church concept of the church, while H. U. Sverdrup rejected it. Both men are known as friends of the work for spirit and life.

Greve says:

"If we ask where the church is to be found on earth, then, according to our confession, we ask: Where is the Word preached purely, where are the Sacraments rightly administered? And where we find that this takes place, there we recognize the congregation to be. But then we turn our gaze to the local congregation; we cannot turn it elsewhere; even if it consisted of only two or three gathered in Jesus' name, we must in it see the church made manifest. Greve teaches that the visible forms of manifestation are the church's forms of manifestation, and that accordingly the true church of Jesus Christ in empirical reality comes forth in the visible congregations, there where the Word is preached purely and the Sacraments rightly administered. In other words: Not in an ecclesiastical organization embracing all Christians, nor yet in a mighty hierarchical order with a pope as supreme head, do we find the church, but in the local congregations, where the Word is rightly preached, etc., even where only two or three are assembled in Jesus' name. We must acknowledge such an assembly, gathered around Word and Sacrament, as a congregation of Christ, a congregation of God; in such a congregation we see "the communion of saints," "the body of Christ," made manifest in a visible form of existence on earth."

This means: according to Scripture, the congregation is the right form of the kingdom of God on earth—which is precisely what the adherents of the state church and of the national church reject. Therefore Greve says:

"What, at bottom, is the fault among both the men of the state church and the adherents of the national church? They raise their building upon a foundation that fails; they build upon a false concept of the church," etc.

To this H. U. Sverdrup replies:

"I maintain that in ordinary Norwegian this can only mean that in the constitutional question the men of the state church and the adherents of the national church are, broadly speaking, one, only that the men of the state church, or their theories, are perhaps a little worse in any case, for they are altogether impossible."

Greve maintains that there is only one form of manifestation for the body of Christ. It is precisely the local congregation that is the body of Christ.

H. U. Sverdrup, on the other hand, maintains that there are many kinds of forms of manifestation. No visible form of existence can claim to be the body of Christ. He says:

"The Lutheran concept of the church has, within the evangelical division of the church, allowed itself to be joined with the most various forms of polity, the free-church forms as well, provided only that these, like this concept of the church itself, are of a national-church character. The 'free-church concept' leads by inward consequence to the voluntaristic church with congregational order. For biblical and Lutheran thought, the legitimacy of the Free Church is dependent upon special conditions (the time of beginnings, the time of persecution, the end time); and since these conditions are always something that the church must seek to overcome, the Free Church (that is, the voluntaristic Free Church) will never stand as a goal that for principal reasons ought to be striven after. But this is precisely what the 'free-churchmen,' by virtue of their concept of the church, do. And indeed to such a degree that they designate the folk-church formation of the church as a deep fall."

H. U. Sverdrup thus rejects that line of thought which makes the church's outward form something essential. Indeed he says:

"The concept of the free-churchmen is neither Lutheran, nor ancient-church, nor biblical, whereas the concept of the church among the adherents of the state church and of the national church—precisely in the essential point that the church as the communion of saints, as the body of Christ, is invisible, and that it cannot in any visible form of existence claim to be this—agrees both with the Lutheran confession, the ancient-church conception, and with Scripture."

Thus: the foregoing shows that there is fairly strong opposition to principle no. 1. It would be too lengthy to illuminate the other principles in this manner. Those who wish to have them illuminated will find them illuminated in the literature on church polity.

The leading principles do not stand alone. But there lies a whole history behind them. They attempt to apply the Reformation principle of "the universal priesthood" to the local congregation and to the relation between the local congregations. The reason they are so little understood among us is doubtless the high-church upbringing which has entered into the blood even of many of the ablest and most zealous spokesmen of the revival: that direction which has set its stamp upon Krogh-Tønning's doctrinal theology has also strongly influenced the home, religious instruction, the pulpit, the church press, indeed the whole of Christian thinking.

There are doubtless several directions that have been negatively determinative for the leading principles. Thus the high-church tendency in Norway, with men like Heuch and Bugge at its head and with its many heirs in this country. We need not enter into these tendencies, but will only say that the leading principles have sought to make front against them.

It is of importance just now that we become more closely acquainted with the directions which, theoretically considered, have been positively determinative for the shaping of the principles and for the interpretation which their authors have given them.

If I am not mistaken, the authors have been influenced by four closely related currents:

1. The authors were strongly influenced by the ecclesiastical reform movement on the west coast of Norway. In principle it recognized lay activity as something that normally belongs in an evangelical congregation. It maintained a democratic view of the ministerial office. It taught that all ecclesiastical right has its root in the congregation. In other words: it "interpreted the cause of religious liberty and congregational liberty" (Samlede Skrifter II, 201–211). This tendency found early expression in *Luthersk Kirketidende*. Later it received its organ in *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*, edited by Jakob Sverdrup and O. Volla (1877–81). It was zealously opposed by *Luthersk Ugeskrift*, edited by Bugge and Heuch, who were then high-church.

To those who wish to know what polity is, we recommend *Ny luthersk Kirketidende*. Krogh-Tønning polemicized much against this paper and wrote of it in 1880: "The paper occupies itself almost exclusively with its favorite ideas about reforms in church polity; and it is precisely these that can only be explained by Reformed spirit, the spirit of Independency."

He meant that the paper had fixed its gaze so blindly upon evangelical freedom that it had no sight for ecclesiastical authority; it had "a concept of the Christians' spiritual priesthood which is at variance with the concept of the special priesthood"; it shut itself off from the truth that the office is instituted by God; it lacked the view of Jesus Christ's church as the 'one' and 'catholic'; and without further ado, in independentist fashion, transferred all right and power to the single local congregation. So much for Tønning.

2. Sverdrup and Oftedal nevertheless went further than the reform movement, for which the congregation was only the center of gravity in the ecclesiastical organization. They made the congregation the church itself, the only right form of the kingdom of God on earth. According to S. and O., the local congregation is an institution *de jure divino*.

But this is precisely the doctrine of the older Congregationalists (down to about 1870), although the newer school of Congregationalists maintains that there is no prescribed church form in the New Testament. To be sure, it finds no other church form in the New Testament than the local congregation, but it no longer constructs a *de jure divino* polity on that basis. At the very most it regards the congregational form as something recommended, but not as something commanded. These are the ideas of the newer school, whereas S. and O. follow the old one with respect to the idea of the congregation's divine institution.

The Congregationalists also went a step further than the friends of reform did in the democratic understanding of the ministerial office. They were very free with regard to lay activity and had no objection to a layman's administering the Sacraments on the congregation's behalf. But with respect both to the reception of members into the congregation and to church discipline, they were legal-minded, and therefore in this area diverged from S. and O., who here sought, as far as possible, to preserve evangelical freedom. In this respect the Congregationalists were more consistent than S. and O., who thought that logic must bend to life, although others object that principle no. 1 is a false premise, where life in reality bends to logic.

If S. and O. held the older Congregationalists' view of principle no. 1 (the congregation is the right form) and of the equality of the congregation's members within the congregational organism, they also shared their view with regard to the relation between the congregations. In his address "Free association among free congregations," 1897, Oftedal declared that the Lutheran Free Church, in the sense presented in his address, was "truly the old, good church order given of itself by the Word of God, in contrast to clerical rule, communal tyranny, and the state-church system."

How far S. and O. had acquainted themselves with the constitutional literature of the Congregationalists (and Baptists) is not easy to determine. It is possible that they did not

concern themselves much further with it, although Oftedal, as a church historian, must surely have known a good deal of it. It is possible that they took counsel with little besides the New Testament. In any case, Norway, despite the Haugean and Johnsonian revival, had not taught them much about the congregation. "There was no one in Norway," said Sverdrup, "who taught us anything about the free congregation or the true nature and form of Christ's church, so that we all came over here rather unenlightened and without understanding in the things that belong to a free church body" (S. S. II, 101).

But one thing must not be left unsaid. Oftedal and Sverdrup used the same arguments to prove the scripturalness of their conception of the congregation and of their view of the office, lay activity, and church organization as the Congregationalists did. The sequences of argument are strikingly alike, which they can only be when the presuppositions are the same. This applies not only to the adducing of scriptural proof, but also to the polemic against the arguments which the opponents of the congregational principle have brought into the field. Everything came together in asserting that the congregation is the body of Christ, that it is therefore free and independent, that the other ecclesiastical organizations are human arrangements, and that the universal priesthood receives its application precisely in the congregation.

(To be continued.)